STEP 1: CAREER & INCOME

Choose a career and calculate your monthly take-home pay.

MISSION #1

My name _____ **Date** _____

1 Pick a real career

U.S. median pay, 2025—not a starting salary. Assume 40 paid hours each week.



Graphic designer

Make colorful designs

$30.27 / hour



Veterinary technician

Help care for animals

$22.78 / hour



Software developer

Build apps and programs

$65.38 / hour

2 Find your monthly income

Gross pay is money earned before taxes. Take-home pay is what you can budget.

Work rule: 40 hours/week × 52 weeks/year ÷ 12 months

1. Weekly gross pay	_____ × 40 =	_____
2. Average monthly gross	_____ × 52 ÷ 12 =	_____
3. Estimated monthly taxes Federal + NC + Social Security/Medicare		_____

Monthly take-home pay

Monthly gross – estimated taxes. Use this for your budget. _____

Our example household

One adult renting in Raleigh, North Carolina. Pay uses 2025 national medians; tax rules and local cost references are from 2026. Expenses are realistic planning estimates, not exact bills. A month is not always four weeks.

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What is your gross pay for a whole year?

_____

STEP 2: HOUSING & TRANSPORTATION

Compare homes, utility bills, and monthly transportation costs.

MISSION #2

A **need** helps you live and stay well, like food and a safe home. Choose a home and travel for one adult. All costs below are monthly.

1 Choose your home

Raleigh rental scenarios—not mortgages or measured averages by home type.



Cozy apartment
1 bedroom · 750 sq ft



Townhouse
2 bedrooms · 1,200 sq ft



House
3 bedrooms · 1,800 sq ft

Estimated rent and utility bills · per month

Monthly bill	Apartment	Townhouse	House
Rent only	**$1,300**	**$1,900**	**$2,300**
Electricity Includes heating & cooling	$105	$150	$210
Water & sewer	$60	$75	$80
Trash	$20	$25	$30
Utilities only Rent is NOT included	**$185**	**$250**	**$320**

Estimates for all-electric homes. Bigger spaces, weather, water use, and the lease change bills. Internet is budgeted separately. How we estimated these bills.

2 Choose how to travel

Choose a monthly travel plan. The car amount includes more than its payment.



Walk or bike
$20 / month



Public Transit
$80 / month



Used car
$780 / month

Transport bills · per month

Monthly bill	Walk / bike	Public Transit	Used car
Car payment	N/A	N/A	$350
Gas / fuel	N/A	N/A	$150
Vehicle insurance	N/A	N/A	$160
Public Transit pass	N/A	$80	N/A
Maintenance & repairs	$20	N/A	$100
Registration & vehicle taxes	N/A	N/A	$20
Total monthly transport	**$20**	**$80**	**$780**

N/A means no bill for that option. Public Transit uses GoTriangle's $80 adult monthly fare cap. Car costs are estimates for about 1,000 miles/month; maintenance and yearly registration are monthly set-asides. Costs & assumptions.

STEP 2: HOUSING & TRAVEL TOTALS

Record your selected home and transportation costs.

MISSION #2

Use your selected home and travel plan from the previous page. Add rent, utilities, transportation, and renters insurance. Daily living bills are on Step 3.

Rent only	_____
Utilities only	_____
Transportation	_____
Renters insurance	$20
Housing & transportation subtotal	_____

Why did you choose this home or way to travel?

STEP 3: LIFESTYLE & SAVINGS

Plan daily living expenses, lifestyle bills, and monthly savings.

MISSION #3

Budget for one adult in Raleigh, NC. All amounts are monthly estimates. These living bills are separate from the housing and transportation costs in Step 2.

Daily Living & Lifestyle Bills

Groceries & food	$400
Home internet / Wi-Fi	$70
Mobile phone plan	$55
Health insurance & medical care	$280
Clothing, toiletries & household supplies	$150
Streaming services & gaming	$30
Monthly living-bills subtotal	**$985**

Pay Yourself First: Savings

Savings goal _____

Monthly savings amount $ _____

Choose Your Fun-Money Budget

Free outings	Dining out & treats	Movies & hobbies
$0 / month	$50 / month	$100 / month

Selected fun-money allowance	_____
Monthly savings	_____
Total lifestyle & savings	_____

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If you save the same amount for 3 months, how much will you have?

_____

Name: _____ Food and medical benchmarks: MIT. Internet/phone: Numbeo. Other amounts are monthly planning allowances.

STEP 4: BUDGET CHECK & REFLECTION

Compare your monthly income with expenses and savings.

FINAL STEP

A **budget** is a plan for your money. Let's see if your monthly take-home pay covers your needs, wants, and savings.

Monthly take-home pay	_____
Housing & transportation	_____
Daily living & lifestyle bills	$985
Money for savings	_____
Money for wants	_____
Money I planned	_____

Take-home pay – money planned =

Money left over

_____

If your answer is below $0, change a choice. If it is $0 or more, your monthly plan fits!

1. Does your plan fit? What could you change?

2. Which need or want costs the most in your plan?

3. Surprise! You need to replace something that broke. It costs $150. Can your leftover money cover it? What else could you do?

★ **OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE**

What percent of your income did you save?

(Monthly savings ÷ monthly take-home pay) × 100. A calculator can help.

_____